

Journal — June 2026

A Month of Building

June 2026 has been a significant month. After my third kidney transplant and finding myself without a job following Wilko's closure, I decided to properly commit to a career change into tech — specifically DevOps/DevSecOps. I've always been interested in technology, and this felt like the right time to turn that into something more.

The Learning

I've been working through Misha van den Burg's Free Linux Course on Skool, and I'm also halfway through his Advanced course. Sections covered so far include Users/Groups/Permissions, Vi(m) Basics, Input/Output & Pipes, Processes, and SSH. The course is genuinely good — it explains fundamentals clearly without talking down to you, and the community around it is helpful, encouraging, and full of people at different stages of the same journey. That community aspect has been genuinely valuable — knowing there are others working through the same material, asking the same questions, and sharing what they've learned makes a real difference when you're doing this largely on your own.

Alongside the course, I've been using Claude (Anthropic's AI assistant) as a learning tool — running quizzes on topics I've just covered, working through simulated scenarios (such as being called in as a sysadmin to diagnose a broken server), and asking questions until concepts actually make sense rather than just look familiar. It's been a surprisingly effective way to reinforce what the course teaches, and to bridge the gap between theory and practical understanding.

The Community and the Path Forward

I've had a conversation with Laura Van den Burg (Misha's wife), who reached out personally after I posted in the forum. The roadmap session on Tuesday 17th June should give me a clearer picture of the path forward, though I suspect it's partly an introduction to the Kubecraft Career Accelerator programme.

The cost of Kubecraft is a genuine concern right now — but I've been thinking about what you actually get for it. The technical content can largely be found elsewhere for free (KubeAcademy, School of Kubernetes, official documentation), but what Kubecraft offers that's harder to replicate is the community, the mentorship, the accountability, and the job hunting strategy. For a career changer in their 50s with health complications, that kind of structured support and human connection could be the difference between getting there and not getting there. It's not just a course — it's an investment in a support network.

If Kubecraft isn't financially possible in the near term, the plan is to work through the cert roadmap independently: CompTIA Linux+, Security+, possibly Network+, AWS Cloud Practitioner, and CySA+. There are solid free and low-cost alternatives for the technical content — KubeAcademy's Kubernetes Learning Path, School of Kubernetes, and A Cloud Guru among others — and the homelab itself provides the practical environment to reinforce everything. The goal is to build real,

demonstrable skills, not just collect certificates.

The Homelab

The centrepiece of all of this is nezuko — my HP OMEN laptop running Ubuntu 26.04 LTS headlessly as a home server. Named by my niece after the character from Demon Slayer, she's been rock solid. This month I:

- Got nezuko stable on the network using Tailscale (permanent IP: 100.76.26.45) after a failed static IP attempt taught me a valuable lesson about DHCP + Tailscale being the more reliable approach
- Set up Jellyfin via Docker for media streaming (currently direct playing to the Fire TV Stick downstairs)
- Configured dual network interfaces — ethernet preferred (metric 100), WiFi as fallback (metric 600)
- Completed SSH key authentication setup, switching from password auth to ed25519 key pairs. Password authentication is now fully disabled. ssh nezuko connects instantly.
- Updated WinSCP to use key authentication too

The GitHub Repo

One of the things I'm most pleased with this month is setting up a public GitHub repo — homelab-journey — to document everything. The idea is that it serves two purposes: keeping me accountable in my learning, and building a portfolio that demonstrates real practical skills to future employers.

If you're a potential employer reading this — this repo is the journey, not just the destination. Every guide, every note, every troubleshooting session documented here represents something I actually worked through, got stuck on, figured out, and wrote up. The SSH key authentication guide wasn't written from a textbook — it was written after going through the process step by step, hitting the problems, fixing them, and making sure the next person (or future me) has a clear path through. That's the kind of thinking I'm trying to bring to a role in DevOps/DevSecOps.

So far the repo contains:

- A journal section (this being the first monthly entry)
- Four guides: Linux Server Setup (with and without router access), GitHub Workflow, and SSH Key Authentication
- A reference section with a Linux Troubleshooting flowchart and written guide
- Rack build plans and photos of the current setup
- Study notes from the course

I shared the troubleshooting flowchart on Misha's Skool forum and got a positive response — 6 likes and 4 comments. Small start, but a start.

The Rack Build

The plan is taking shape. Month 1 is the rack frame (GeeekPi 8U, patch panel, PDU — around £215, eyeing Prime Day 23–26 June). Month 2 adds MilimNava — a Raspberry Pi 5 8GB with NVMe SSD. Phase 2 brings shalltear — a Beelink EQ12 running Proxmox. All named after powerful supernatural female anime characters, naturally.

Thoughts

It's been a lot to take in, and there have been moments of frustration (the static IP saga, WinSCP refusing to connect after disabling password auth). But working through those problems has probably been more valuable than if everything had just worked first time. That's the thing about a homelab — it's not a sanitised learning environment. Things break. You have to figure it out. And when you do, you actually understand why.

Age is a concern. Health disclosure at interviews is a concern. But I'm doing this anyway — building something real, documenting it properly, and taking it one step at a time. The daemons never sleep, and neither does the determination to get there.

■ "All systems nominal. Nezuko stands watch."